

THE BRIEF

AUDIENCE  
Rural-focused funders,  
philanthropies & policymakers

FRAMING  
Grant-seeking • place-based income  
engine

THE REFRAME  
Not a staffing patch — a rural  
prosperity instrument

THE ASK  
Fund expansion across a national →  
regional → local supporter pipeline

KEY SIGNALS

3M

NCAD completions  
target by 2035

~\$2M

Carnegie Corp. —  
Delta Region

~\$1M

The Goodness Web —  
behavioral health

\$0

Debt at graduation —  
paid throughout

THREADS

Economic Mobility

Grow-Your-Own

Teacher Pipeline

Healthcare

Earn-and-Learn

Brain-Drain

National policy tailwind for learn-while-you-earn  
(US DOL; GAO 2025). Figures are draft and  
pending verification against primary Reach /  
government sources.

The Apprenticeship Degree is a rural income  
engine, not just a teacher-pipeline fix.

It starts with a paid job and ends with a better one — debt-free, fully accredited, work-embedded. The raise lands in place, keeps talent and its wages local instead of exporting them, and compounds into a local-economy multiplier — exactly what communities facing workforce shortages and out-migration need.

- ▶ **Paid throughout, debt-free.** The learner is an employee earning wages the whole way, so the post-credential raise is **net** income — worth more where baseline incomes are lower (GAO 2025; PPI).
- ▶ **The raise is the point.** The terminal step is licensure — paraprofessional/aide → **licensed teacher** — unlocking a materially higher-paid role in the same community (wage delta  $\Delta$  verify).
- ▶ **Stays local.** The worksite is the campus, so nobody has to leave to earn the credential — the income gain recirculates instead of relocating to a metro.

01 THE RURAL BIND

A self-reinforcing loop: chronic **workforce shortages** (teachers first, then healthcare), limited access to affordable degrees, and steady **out-migration** of anyone who earns a credential — brain drain that exports both talent and the income that talent would have earned and spent locally.

03 WHY IT FITS RURAL

**Talent stays in place** — the credential and the raise both land locally. **Debt-aversion is higher and incomes lower**, so a debt-free path converts candidates who'd never take loans. **Employer-embedded** — districts and health systems co-design, so the pipeline is demand-driven. And it's **generalizing** beyond teaching — the Apprenticeship College of Health targets healthcare deserts.

02 WHY INCOME RISES

- **Paid throughout** — wages while studying; higher pay, little debt, better retention (GAO 2025).
- **Debt-free** — no loan payments clawing back the raise (PPI 2025).
- **Role upgrade** — licensure unlocks a higher-wage role.
- **Retention** — grow-your-own apprentices stay; districts "no longer need job fairs."

04 SUPPORTER PIPELINE

- **National** — expansion + credibility. In: Carnegie Corp. (~\$2M, Delta), The Goodness Web (~\$1M).
- **Regional** — state education/workforce agencies & foundations matching national grants to local delivery.
- **Local** — where income lands: employers, community foundations, local business co-funding.

THE RAISE IS  
THE POINT

Fund a **place-based income engine** that lifts household earnings, solves the employer's shortage with grow-your-own talent, and compounds into a local multiplier as raised wages recirculate. Most fundable when the reader sees money already flowing at the top of the pipeline (Carnegie, Goodness Web) and a clear on-ramp for regional and local co-funding beneath it. Anchored by **NCAD** and its goal of **3M Apprenticeship Degree completions by 2035**.

**Sources:** Inside Higher Ed, "Rural Opportunity Through Apprenticeship" (2026) • Progressive Policy Institute, "The Apprenticeship Degree" (2025) • GAO-25-107040, "Earn-And-Learn Opportunities" • New America, "Mapping the Landscape of Degree Apprenticeship" • Reach blog (Carnegie \$2M; Goodness Web \$1M; Apprenticeship College of Health; NCAD 3M by 2035) • AIR, "A New State Solution for Teacher Shortages" — draft narrative; figures pending verification.